THE MADE IN INDIA DEFENCE

The ministry and the military admirably tackled the twin blows of Covid and China, with the last giving a fillip to self-reliance in defence

By Abhishek Bhalla



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SUMMER 2020. AS THE COUNTRY nervously regarded the steady ingress of the Covid-19 pandemic, the sudden Chinese aggression on the arid and cold high-altitude plateau of Ladakh dealt a twin blow to the Indian military. A different two-front threat confronted them: not Pakistan and China, for which they had been preparing, but Covid and China. At a time when the military had to chip in with logistics to fight the pandemic, the Chinese stealthily struck at the Line of Actual Control (LAC), inching forward on Indian held territory.

With a steady build-up of troops, armour and heavy equipment on the Chinese side, the Indian war machinery swung into action—jumbo C-17 transport aircraft of the Indian Air Force (IAF) made quick sorties to Ladakh from its base in Hindon near Delhi, air-dropping heavy military equipment, men and material, ensuring there was no shortage of supplies to troops in Ladakh, which over the next few months had swelled to over 50,000. Alongside helping safeguard the border, the aircraft flew around the globe, bringing in large oxygen tankers as thousands of people sick with Covid gasped for breath. Even Indian Navy ships were part of Covid relief operations, as the country faced its biggest military threat in years at the border with China.

For defence minister Rajnath Singh, the three forces and high-ranking officials of the defence ministry,

WHAT'S DONE

- Over 100 bridges, roads, tunnels inaugurated in border areas
- Big push to road connectivity along LAC
- Integration of the three services through joint planning
- Procedures being worked out to integrate defence planning, procurement and operations
- Over 4,000 Indians evacuated from Iran, China, Maldives, Sri Lanka and Iran during pandemic
- Defence forces set up quarantine facilities at 21 locations along with Covid-19 hospitals